

Piano Lessons for Absolute Beginners

Lesson 7: Combining Hands: 'Mary Had a Little Lamb'

Combining Hands: 'Mary Had a Little Lamb' - Study Notes

Key Concepts

- **Hand Coordination:** The ability to have your left and right hands perform different actions simultaneously and in sync.
- **Melody & Accompaniment:** Understanding the difference between the main tune (melody) and a supporting musical part (accompaniment).
- **Chord Progression (C Major):** Recognizing and playing a basic chord (C Major) and its role in supporting the melody.
- **Rhythmic Accuracy:** Maintaining a consistent beat and playing notes at the correct time.
- **Independent Hand Practice:** The importance of mastering each hand individually before combining them.

Summary

This lesson introduces the fundamental skill of combining your hands while playing. We'll be using the familiar tune "Mary Had a Little Lamb" as our example. The right hand will focus on playing the melody, while the left hand provides a simple harmonic foundation with a C Major chord played on the first beat of each measure. The initial focus is on building coordination – a crucial element for more complex musical pieces.

The process involves breaking down the task into manageable steps: first, practice the right hand melody until it's comfortable. Then, practice the left hand's C Major chord on the first beat of each measure. Only after both hands are individually secure should you attempt to play them together, starting slowly and gradually increasing the tempo. Remember, this exercise is designed to build muscle memory and improve your ability to play different parts simultaneously.

Don't be discouraged if coordinating your hands feels awkward at first. It's a common challenge for beginners. Consistent, focused practice is the key to success. By mastering this simple exercise, you'll lay a solid foundation for playing more complex pieces with both hands.

Important Points

- **Right Hand:** Plays the melody: E-D-C-D-E-E-E. Focus on accurate notes and rhythm.
- **Left Hand:** Plays a C Major chord (C-E-G) on the *first beat* of each measure. Ensure a clear and consistent sound.
- **Practice Separately:** Master each hand individually *before* attempting to combine them. This is vital for success.
- **Start Slowly:** Begin at a very slow tempo to ensure accuracy and coordination. Gradually increase speed as you become more comfortable.
- **Focus on Rhythm:** Pay close attention to the timing of both hands. Use a metronome if possible.
- **Listen Carefully:** Actively listen to how the melody and chord interact.
- **Be Patient:** Coordination takes time and practice. Don't get frustrated; keep practicing!

Examples

****Example 1: Measure 1****

- ****Right Hand:**** Plays E-D-C
- ****Left Hand:**** Plays C Major chord (C-E-G) on the first beat.
- ****Explanation:**** The left hand provides the harmonic support while the right hand introduces the beginning of the melody. The timing is crucial – the C Major chord **must** be played on the first beat.

****Example 2: Measure 2****

- ****Right Hand:**** Plays D-E-E-E
- ****Left Hand:**** Plays C Major chord (C-E-G) on the first beat.
- ****Explanation:**** The left hand continues to provide the harmonic foundation, while the right hand continues the melody. Maintaining a steady rhythm is key to making the two parts sound cohesive.

Quick Review

1. What notes does the right hand play for the melody in "Mary Had a Little Lamb"?
2. What chord does the left hand play, and on what beat of the measure?
3. Why is it important to practice each hand separately before combining them?
4. What is the main benefit of this exercise for a beginner pianist?
5. If you're struggling to coordinate your hands, what should you do?

Further Reading

- ****Basic Music Theory:**** Explore the fundamentals of music theory, including scales, chords, and key signatures.
- ****Rhythm Exercises:**** Practice exercises specifically designed to improve your rhythmic accuracy.
- ****Simple Chord Progressions:**** Learn other common chord progressions in C Major and other keys.
- ****Two-Handed Exercises (Hanon):**** Explore Hanon exercises, which are designed to build finger strength and coordination.
- ****Easy Piano Songs:**** Look for other beginner-friendly piano songs that involve playing different parts with each hand.

